

THE MIDDLE EAST

Between the 11th and 16th centuries, the weapons and armour of the Islamic world displayed greater variation than that of their western counterparts, although the most common type of armour was a mail coat (a *dir* or *zirh*), which was similar to the mail hauberk of European knights. Islamic helmets were most often conical, egg- or turban-shaped, and of metal or organic material. Swords were generally straight and double-edged until the 11th century, when cavalry sabres appeared under Turkish influence. Islamic armies employed a large number of horse archers, as well as cavalry bearing lances and swords, while the infantry carried maces and a variety of pole-arm weapons.



▲ ÇIÇEK HELMET

Date c.1525–1550

Origin Anatolia

Material Steel, silver, gilt

◀ ISLAMIC SWORD

Date 12th–13th century

Origin Spain or Sicily

Length 89.5cm (35in)

Most early Islamic blades were straight, rather than curved. This wide, double-edged blade with a disc-shaped pommel lacks quillons. The grip, which was probably made of leather, has also perished. The blade bears inscriptions in Persian on both sides.

▶ MAMLUK AXE

Date c.1400

Origin Syria

Length 69cm (27in)

This ceremonial axe, with its asymmetrical, crescent-shaped blade, probably belonged to Mamluk Emir Nawruz al-Hafizi. He was executed for staging a revolt against the sultan in 1413–14.

Made in the turban shape characteristic of many Islamic helmets, this parade helmet belonged to a grand vizier of the Ottoman Sultan, Suleyman the Magnificent (see p.130). It is decorated in gold with Koranic inscriptions and arabesques.



Short
mail sleeve



Protective
collar

Steel links

▶ MAIL AND PLATE ARMOUR

Date Late 15th century

Origin Anatolia

Material Steel, silver, gilt

This mail and plate armour is characteristic of the Ak Koyunlu Turkomans, who ruled eastern Anatolia and parts of the Caucasus from 1378 to 1508. Plates of partly gilded silver were added on a base of mail to reinforce the central section. Although this piece is ceremonial, it was for use on the battlefield.